

Chapter 116-1

Liang Shi's gaze swept over Liang Xinran, then over Liang Xinzhou.

Liang Xinran raised the back of her hand to wipe her tears. With reddened eyes, she said, "It wasn't until I came here that I realized I don't fit in. I can't integrate into this family, but you're different. You grew up here since you were little. The brothers all dote on you, and even Wanwan and Ling Dang like you more. I missed out on them. After I came, I did many wrong things. I'm truly sorry. I'm leaving now, but you can still be family with them. Take care of each other."

Her tone was sincere. The way she looked at Liang Shi was aggrieved and innocent. Her face was as pale as paper, with not a trace of color on her lips.

She looked weak and powerless.

Even Liang Xinran's voice was very soft when she spoke, as if a gust of wind could blow her away.

But her words made Liang Shi very uncomfortable.

Mainly because Liang Xinran's true identity was right there. Saying this to Liang Shi, the underlying meaning was—although you stole my parents and siblings, and took away the affection that should have belonged to me, I'm willing to give all of this to you. After all, I didn't grow up by their side, so none of them like me, right?

Liang Shi clearly hadn't done anything, yet now she was being made out to be the villain no matter how you looked at it.

Anyone looking at such a pale face wouldn't be able to say anything more. If it were someone soft-hearted like Liang Xinhe, they might even ask her to stay.

Liang Shi was also kind, but she knew kindness should be reserved for good people.

Being kind to everyone would make her a saint.

Liang Xinran wasn't as tall as Liang Shi, so Liang Shi had to look down at her. After a moment, Liang Shi said coldly, "Oh, then have a safe trip."

Liang Xinran: "..."

Obviously, a flash of astonishment passed through her eyes, but she quickly recovered.

Liang Shi didn't pay her any attention. Instead, she said to Liang Xinzhou, "Big Brother, you've worked hard. I'll take good care of Ling Dang."

Liang Xinzhou nodded at her. "Mm, don't tire yourself out either."

Liang Shi nodded and smiled. "I know."

The two of them had this harmonious interaction right there, completely leaving Liang Xinran hanging.

Watching the two of them, Liang Xinran was grinding her teeth in frustration, but she couldn't show any of it.

She still maintained that weak appearance. When Liang Xinzhou started walking toward the car again, Liang Xinran passed by Liang Shi's side. Just then, a gust of wind blew, and she lost her footing, falling directly toward Liang Shi.

Liang Shi instinctively wanted to reach out to support her, but she quickly came to her senses. In that split second, she pulled back her hand and quickly shifted to the side, away from her.

Liang Xinran lost her balance, her body floating unsteadily, her feet scrambling on the ground. She had already let herself fall, intending to land in Liang Shi's arms, but she hadn't expected Liang Shi to dodge. She could only try to regain her balance this way, looking like she was dancing.

It took a lot of effort before Liang Xinran finally steadied herself.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi stood with her arms crossed, looking completely uninvolved.

Liang Xinzhou had already walked to the car. Looking back and seeing Liang Xinran still standing there, he frowned and asked coldly, "Do you have anything else?"

"No," Liang Xinran said, sniffing accordingly, looking extremely aggrieved. Tears fell like water from an opened floodgate, continuously streaming down. But she stubbornly raised the back of her hand to wipe them away, like a little white flower swaying precariously in the cold wind.

Afraid she would pull another stunt, Liang Shi moved even further away from her.

Liang Xinran looked at her and smiled. "You're luckier than me. You have parents who love you, brothers who love you, and a younger sister who respects you. To be honest, I'm very envious, but I know I don't deserve to have these things. Life is a one-way track. My life was switched to a different track over twenty years ago. I have nothing to complain about. I just hope you can take good care of them in my place. Thank you."

Liang Shi: "...?"

If one didn't know better, they'd think she was performing a melodrama here.

Honestly, couldn't Liang Xinran become a hit if she became a screenwriter?

Her ability to make up lines was truly impressive.

Liang Shi listened to her words, standing there with her mind wandering.

But she didn't really take in what she was saying.

Praise on the surface, criticism underneath.

Liang Shi had heard plenty of this kind of talk before in the entertainment industry.

On the surface, they acted like good sisters, saying your journey hasn't been easy and you should be happy to have achieved so much. But the actual meaning was: you country bumpkin, who knows what kind of dumb luck you stepped in to transform from a plain chicken into a phoenix. But so what? That's as far as you'll ever go.

Liang Shi was basically immune to this kind of talk.

She hadn't done anything wrong to anyone, so she didn't care what others said.

Liang Xinran had put on a big show with no audience to appreciate it, only receiving Liang Shi's casual remark in return: "Do you not actually want to leave?"

Liang Xinran was startled, like a frightened little white rabbit. "How could that be? I'm leaving, it's just..."

She paused, then mumbled in a voice everyone could hear, "I just don't know where to go. I don't have a home anymore."

Just then, Liang Xinzhou had put down her luggage and was walking back. Hearing this, his footsteps paused slightly, his expression complicated.

Liang Shi clicked her tongue internally but said coldly, "Isn't this your home? Why don't you just stay?"

"I can't," Liang Xinran said. "The brothers and sister don't like me. I can't stay here."

Hearing this, Liang Xinzhou's expression became even more complicated.

Wasn't she directly saying—because the place I grew up in wasn't good, coming from a small mountain village, my family members all don't like me. That must be their problem, not mine.

Standing there, Liang Xinzhou suddenly spoke. "Liang Xinran, if you want people to like you, you first need to show your personal merits, not stand here playing the victim and acting pitiful. You didn't have good material conditions in Taozhi Village, but you clearly already created good enough conditions for yourself before. Although I don't know what you traded to get them, your annual salary is equivalent to that of a mid-level employee at Dongheng, even if they're top graduates from 985 or 211 universities."¹

Liang Xinzhou's words were very direct. His tall figure standing there gave off enough pressure.

"If you feel the Liang family hasn't given you enough, you can ask for more," Liang Xinzhou said. "I don't see how much you're lacking family. Your home is here, and you can come back anytime. But you shouldn't expect so much. We've all established our own families and careers. To be honest, even Liang Shi—I don't have much energy to spare for her. Yet you want everyone to revolve around you."

Liang Xinzhou adjusted his glasses. Those eyes hidden behind the lenses were sharp and piercing. The words he spoke were like a knife, precisely stabbing into Liang Xinran's weak spot.

Liang Xinzhou slowly uttered a few words: "Wishful thinking."

Footnotes:

¹ 985 and 211 universities: These refer to two prestigious university programs in China. "Project 985" includes China's top 39 research universities (like Peking University and Tsinghua University), while "Project 211" includes about 100 key universities. Graduates from these institutions are highly sought after in the job market. Liang Xinzhou is pointing out that Liang Xinran's previous income was already comparable to elite graduates, implying she wasn't as unfortunate as she claims.